

Lesson 15: “Seek Ye Earnestly the Best Gifts” (See L15 [Class Member Study Guide](#))

Purpose: To help us identify gifts of the Spirit, seek to obtain them, and use them to serve others.

Historical Context: [D&C 46](#) *Our Heritage*: [pages 42-43](#), [47-48](#), [63](#)

1. All faithful members of the Church can receive gifts of the Spirit.

“Gifts of the Spirit are spiritual blessings or abilities that are given through the Holy Ghost. These gifts were taken from the earth during the Great Apostasy, but God restored them in the days of this dispensation. The exercise of these gifts can bless, edify, and unify us.” (*Lesson Manual*)

• D&C 46. What gifts of the Spirit does the Lord identify?

“Gifts of the Spirit are also identified in 1 Corinthians 12:4-12; 1 Corinthians 13:1-13; and Moroni 10:8-18.” (*LM*)

Read the accounts from *Our Heritage*. Which gifts are illustrated in each story?

• D&C 46:8, 11. Who can receive gifts of the Spirit?

“God gives at least one of these gifts to every faithful member of the Church who has received the gift of the Holy Ghost... [Our youth] have spiritual gifts... [Those] who have not received the gift of the Holy Ghost may still be blessed with unique abilities to lift and strengthen others.” (*Lesson Manual*)

2. God gives gifts of the Spirit for the benefit of His children.

According to section 46, what are “some purposes of the Spirit”?

What gifts have been of special value to you? †1. Elder Dallin H. Oaks

• D&C 46:11-12, 26 †2. Elder Orson Pratt

The gifts of the Spirit can help us serve others

How have you been blessed through the spiritual gifts of others? †3. Laura Russell Bunker

3. We should seek and cultivate gifts of the Spirit.

• D&C 46:8. What can we do to discover the spiritual gifts that God has given us?

What can we do to cultivate and develop the spiritual gifts we have been given? †4. The Prophet Joseph Smith

What can we do to seek the gifts of the Spirit?

- D&C 46:7, 20. Ask of God and follow the Spirit’s guidance. †5. President George Q. Cannon
- D&C 46:9. Seek gifts for the benefit of others, not for selfish reasons. †6. Elder Dallin H. Oaks
- D&C 46:31. Do all things in the name of Christ.
- D&C 46:32. Thank God for the gifts He has given us.
- D&C 46:33. Practice virtue and holiness continually.

Additional spiritual gifts

†7. Elder Bruce R. McConkie †8. Elder Marvin J. Ashton

Discerning true gifts of the Spirit

- D&C 50:17-24. Does “he preach it by the Spirit of truth ...? And if it be by some other way it is not of God.”

“A Man without Eloquence” video

Video: “[A Man Without Eloquence](#)” (Brigham Young speaking, about 6 minutes)

Teaching by the Spirit

- Moroni 10:9-10. It is “given by the Spirit of God, that he may teach”.
- D&C 42:13-14. And “if ye receive not the Spirit ye shall not teach.”
- 2 Nephi 33:1. When “a man speaketh by the power of the Holy Ghost” it carries the message to the heart.

What can teachers do to invite the Spirit when they teach?

What can those who are being taught do to invite the Spirit?

Next Week: Lesson 16: “Thou Shalt ... Offer Up Thy Sacraments upon My Holy Day”;

See L1 [Class Member Study Guide](#). † •

(You can download a free LDS Institute manual at: [Doctrine and Covenants Manual: Religion 324 and 325.](#))

†1. **Elder Dallin H. Oaks** taught that gifts of the Spirit “can lead us to God. They can shield us from the power of the adversary. They can compensate for our inadequacies and repair our imperfections” (“[Spiritual Gifts](#),” *Ensign*, Sept. 1986, 72).

†2. **Elder Orson Pratt**: “Spiritual gifts are distributed among the members of the Church, according to their faithfulness, circumstances, natural abilities, duties, and callings; that the whole may be properly instructed, confirmed, perfected, and saved” (*Masterful Discourses and Writings of Orson Pratt*, comp. N. B. Lundwall [1952], 571).

†3. **Laura Russell Bunker**: “As we were busily preparing for a Christmas dinner, my teenaged sister excitedly reached into the cupboard for the silver-rimmed china. The lovely ... set had been Grandmother’s wedding present to Mom and Dad and was used only on special occasions. But as my sister removed some of the precious plates from the cupboard, she bumped her arm and the china slipped from her hands. Her desperate attempts to recover the plates were in vain, and the crash of china shattering on the floor was as heartbreaking as the look of helpless horror on her face.

“Mother’s meal-preparing hands stopped in midair, and the festive chatter of a bustling household ceased as we all stood frozen in awful silence. Without turning around to see the damage, Mother quietly slipped out of the room. Then ... the rest of us tried to resume the tempo of our holiday duties.

“Except my sister. She stood motionless, a big tear trickling down her cheek. As another tear fell, she mechanically found the broom and dustpan and began sweeping up the scattered chips. Then on her knees, she slowly picked up the larger pieces and carefully placed them in the dustpan.

“Within a few minutes Mother returned to the kitchen and wrapped her arms around her grieving daughter. My sister began to sob out loud... Quietly [Mother] soothed, ‘That’s all right, honey; people are more important than things.’

“Mother later told me that she had gone into the other room to pray and was blessed with a peaceful feeling and the inspiration of how to comfort my sister. The gift of spiritual perspective given to my mother that Christmas day became the most priceless gift our family received” (“[Mormon Journal: The Art of Perspective](#),” *Ensign*, Dec. 1998, 54-55).

†4. **The Prophet Joseph Smith** taught that many gifts of the Spirit, such as wisdom or the gift to heal, are not evident until they are needed. He said that “it would require time and circumstances to call these gifts into operation”. (*Teachings of the Prophet Joseph Smith*, sel. Joseph Fielding Smith [1976], 246. Cited in the *Lesson Manual*)

†5. **President George Q. Cannon**: “If any of us are imperfect, it is our duty to pray for the gift that will make us perfect. Have I imperfections? I am full of them. What is my duty? To pray to God to give me the gifts that will correct these imperfections. If I am an angry man, it is my duty to pray for charity, which suffereth long and is kind. Am I an envious man? It is my duty to seek for charity, which envieth not. So with all the gifts of the Gospel. They are intended for this purpose. No man ought to say, ‘Oh, I cannot help this; it is my nature.’ He is not justified in it, for the reason that God has promised to give strength to correct these things, and to give gifts that will eradicate them. If a man lack wisdom, it is his duty to God to ask for wisdom” (*Millennial Star*, 23 Apr. 1894, 260).

†6. **Elder Dallin H. Oaks**: “Having lost her husband, my widowed mother was incomplete. How she prayed for what she needed to fulfill her responsibility to raise her three small children! She was seeking, she was worthy, and she was blessed! Her prayers were answered in many ways, including the receipt of spiritual gifts. She had many, but the ones that stand out in my memory are the gifts of faith, testimony, and wisdom. She was a mighty woman in Zion” (“[Spiritual Gifts](#),” *Ensign*, Sept. 1986, 72).

†7. **Elder Bruce R. McConkie**: “Spiritual gifts are endless in number and infinite in variety. Those listed in the revealed word are simply illustrations” (*A New Witness for the Articles of Faith*, 371).

†8. **Elder Marvin J. Ashton** said some “less-conspicuous gifts” include “the gift of asking; the gift of listening; the gift of hearing and using a still, small voice; ... the gift of avoiding contention; the gift of being agreeable; ... the gift of seeking that which is righteous; the gift of not passing judgment; the gift of looking to God for guidance; the gift of being a disciple; the gift of caring for others; the gift of being able to ponder; the gift of offering prayer; the gift of bearing a mighty testimony; and the gift of receiving the Holy Ghost” (“[There Are Many Gifts](#),” *Ensign*, Nov. 1987, 20).

Recommended Reading:

1. Elder Dallin H. Oaks, “[Spiritual Gifts](#),” *Ensign*, Sept. 1986, 68.
2. Elder Marvin J. Ashton, “[There Are Many Gifts](#),” *Ensign*, Nov. 1987, 20.

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Further Enrichment Resources:

Further Readings:

1. “[Spiritual Promptings](#),” *Ensign*, Sept. 2008, 18.
2. Elder Dallin H. Oaks, “[Eight Ways God Can Speak to You](#),” *New Era*, Sept. 2004, 4.
3. Garnee Faulkner, “[Mormon Journal: Fresh Crab and French Bread](#),” *Ensign*, June 1985, 38; (scroll down).
4. “[Acting on Promptings](#),” *Liahona*, June 2012.
5. Elizabeth Stitt, “[The Miracle of Spiritual Healing](#),” *Liahona*, June 2012.
6. Elder Carlos E. Asay, “[The Companionship of the Holy Ghost](#),” *Ensign*, Apr. 1988, 15.
7. D. Michael Quinn, “[Brigham Young: Man of the Spirit](#),” *Ensign*, Aug. 1977, 34.
8. Elder David A. Bednar, “[Line upon Line, Precept upon Precept](#),” (2 Nephi 28:20) *New Era*, Sep. 2010, 2-7.)

D&C 46:28-33. “He That Asketh in Spirit Shall Receive in Spirit”

“The gifts of the Spirit are available to all who pay the price, which includes entering into a covenant relationship with the Lord, obeying the commandments, and seeking perfection with all one’s heart. The gifts will be the greatest to those who seek most earnestly, but they are available to all: to the missionary who needs help in learning a foreign language, to the person whose temper frequently flares, to parents who seek help in rearing their children. President George Q. Cannon wrote:

“ ‘How many of you ... are seeking for these gifts that God has promised to bestow? How many of you, when you bow before your Heavenly Father in your family circle or in your secret places contend for these gifts to be bestowed upon you? How many of you ask the Father, in the name of Jesus, to manifest Himself to you through these powers and these gifts? Or do you go along day by day like a door turning on its hinges, without having any feeling upon the subject, without exercising any faith whatever; content to be baptized and be members of the Church, and to rest there, thinking that your salvation is secure because you have done this?’ ” (*Millennial Star*, Apr. 1894, p. 260 in the *LDS Institute Manual*, 101).

President Marion G. Romney: “I quote a statement made some time ago by Kurt Waldheim, Secretary-General of the United Nations:

“ ‘... There is an almost universal sense of apprehension about where the tumultuous developments of our time may take us, a sense of deep anxiety at phenomena which we do not fully understand, let alone control... Dire prophecies have often before seen the symptoms of periods of transition and change in human society. What *is* new is the scope and scale of the problems which give rise to these apprehensions...’ ” (United Nations General Assembly address, 30 Aug. 1974; italics added.) ...

“Personally, I am not disheartened. I am concerned, but I do not live in terror...”

“Serious as are our times, however ... **I have unwavering confidence that if we will heed and follow the guidance of the Holy Spirit, the Lord can and will preserve and bring us through safely.**” (“[Guidance of the Holy Spirit](#),” *Ensign*, Jan. 1980, 2.)

Elder David A. Bednar: “We should also endeavor to discern when we ‘withdraw [ourselves] from the Spirit of the Lord, that it may have no place in [us] to guide [us] in wisdom’s paths that [we] may be blessed, prospered, and preserved” (Mosiah 2:36). Precisely because the promised blessing is *that we may always have His Spirit to be with us* (see D&C 20:77), we should attend to and learn from the choices and influences that separate us from the Holy Spirit.

“**The standard is clear. If something we think, see, hear, or do distances us from the Holy Ghost, then we should stop thinking, seeing, hearing, or doing that thing.** If that which is intended to entertain, for example, alienates us from the Holy Spirit, then certainly that type of entertainment is not for us. Because the Spirit cannot abide that which is vulgar, crude, or immodest, then clearly such things are not for us... ” (“[How to Always Have the Spirit to Be with Us](#),” *New Era*, Feb. 2013)

D&C 46:17. To “some is given ... word of wisdom”.

President Stephen L. Richards: “Wisdom is sometimes defined as sound judgment and a high degree of knowledge. **I define wisdom as being the beneficent application of knowledge in decision.** I think of wisdom not in the abstract but as functional. **Life is largely made up of choices and determinations, and I can think of no wisdom that does not contemplate the good of man and society...**” (Conference Report, Apr. 1950, pp. 163-164).

D&C 46:24. The gift of “interpretation of tongues”.

David O. McKay: On the “23rd day of April, 1921, at Puke Tapu Branch, Waikato District, Huntly, New Zealand.

“The service was held in a large tent, beneath the shade of which hundreds of earnest men and women were gathered in anxious anticipation of seeing and hearing an apostle of the Church, the first to visit that land...”

“In other missions I had spoken through an interpreter but, able as all interpreters are, I nevertheless felt hampered—in fact, somewhat—inhibited—in presenting my message.

“Now I faced an audience that had assembled with unusual expectations, and I realized as never before the great responsibility of my office. **From the depth of my soul, I prayed for divine assistance.**

“When I arose to give my address, I said to Brother Stuart Meha, our interpreter, that I would speak without his translating sentence by sentence, what I said. Then to

the audience I continued:

“‘I wish, oh, how I wish I had the power to speak to you in your own tongue, that I might tell you what is in my heart; but since I have not the gift, **I pray, and I ask you to pray, that you might have the gift of interpretation, of discernment, that you may understand at least the spirit while I am speaking,** and then you will get the words and the thought when Brother Meha interprets.’

“**My sermon lasted forty minutes,** and I have never addressed a more attentive, a more respectful audience. My listeners were in perfect rapport—this I knew when I saw tears in their eyes...

“Brother Sidney Christy, a native New Zealander [Maori] who had been a student at Brigham Young University, at the close of my address whispered to me, ‘Brother McKay, they got your message!’

“‘Yes,’ I replied, ‘I think so, but for the benefit of some who may not have understood, we shall have Brother Meha give a synopsis of it in Maori.’

“During the translation, some of the Maoris corrected him on some points, showing that they had a clear conception of what had been said in English.”

...
“On one occasion when I was addressing an audience at Aintab, Syria, I realized that Elder J. Wilford Booth, who was translating into the Turkish language, had interpreted incorrectly a thought I had expressed and, although I did not then—and do not now—understand a word of Turkish, **I stopped Brother Booth in his translation and said, ‘That was the wrong interpretation, Brother Booth.’ I then repeated my sentence.**’

“‘How did you know, Brother McKay?’ he asked. ‘**I gave the opposite meaning.**’” (*Cherished Experiences from the Writings of President David O. McKay*, comp. Clare Middlemiss, 53-56)

Franklin D. Richards: “I recall a testimony given by a **young cadet** attending the United States Air Force Academy.

“**He was experiencing great difficulty in passing his courses and was very discouraged.** At this point, he met a Mormon cadet, and from him he learned that there were a number of Mormon boys attending the academy and that they met together at five o’clock each weekday morning in a religious study class. The cadet was invited to attend one of these classes.

“He did so and was deeply impressed by the wonderful spirit. He continued attending, met the missionaries, was given the discussions, and, through study, prayer, and attending church, received a testimony and was baptized.

“**He bore witness that upon receiving the Holy Ghost he felt its influence quicken his mind and understanding and refresh his memory, and that thereafter he had no trouble in getting satisfactory grades. His feelings of discouragement left him, and a spirit of peace and comfort came over him...**

“...
“

A young father bore witness to me of a great blessing that had come to him and his family. He was awakened one night by a voice that clearly told him to get up and go downstairs. He heeded the warning, and in going into the kitchen he found one wall engulfed in flames. Hurriedly he awakened his family, called the fire department, and with the help of his family fought the fire, keeping it down until the fire department arrived and put it out.

“There was no question in his mind that this warning was a manifestation of the protection the Holy Ghost can give to those who keep their lives in harmony with the Spirit.” (“[The Continuing Power of the Holy Ghost](#),” *Ensign*, July 1973, 116.)

Elder Carlos E. Asay: “**When I was a young man I fell in love with a beautiful girl.** More than anything in the world, I wanted to receive her love and eternal companionship. **I therefore behaved my best, spoke my best, and gave my best as I courted her and sought her favor.** Even after she was promised to me I recognized the need to continue the courting. My desire was, and still is, to please her and to avoid any offense. She is my inspiration, my motivation to live on a high and noble level.

“**The companionship of the Holy Ghost is cultivated in much the same manner.** To obtain his influence and companionship, we must be our best; we must be worthy of his presence...

[Elder Asay lists blessings, and tells stories, e.g.:]

“Would you like to have powers of discernment ... ?

“**While I was a mission president in Texas, I was informed that a particular missionary had lost his testimony and wanted to go home. Some checking disclosed that doubts of the divinity of his call had been planted in the young man’s mind by an investigator. In an interview with the so-called investigator, I experienced special powers of discernment that enabled me to know that the man was a minister of a Protestant faith, posing as a college student and pretending to be an honest examiner of Mormonism. Confronted with the knowledge that had been revealed to me, he became confused and admitted his fraud. With the deceiver out of the way and the truth known, the missionary stayed and completed an honorable mission.**” (“[The Companionship of the Holy Ghost](#),” *Ensign*, Apr. 1988, 15.)

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